THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER ELEVEN

“LET IT BE ME”

February 26 – May 24, 2010
Burbank • Hollywood • Calabasas • View Park • Bel Air

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

FADE IN:

INT. HOLLYWOOD RECORDS - PRESIDENT'S OFFICE - BURBANK - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, FEBRUARY 26, 2010 - 11:00 A.M. PST

A corner office decorated with platinum records. Half of them belong to one man. On a giant poster behind the desk: "TYRESE AVERY - THE AVERY WORLD TOUR 2010 - 94 CITIES - JUNE THROUGH NOVEMBER."

RUSSELL KANE (49), the label's president, slick, tan, gold watch, sits behind the desk. Across from him, in a hoodie and sneakers, slouched in a leather chair, is the most famous pop star in the world: TYRESE AVERY (28).

RUSSELL
No.

TYRESE
I didn't even finish the sentence.

RUSSELL
You said "Marvel," "Captain America," and "audition." I can finish the sentence for you. The answer is no. Ninety-four cities, Tyrese. Two hundred and twelve million dollars in ticket sales. Stadiums are booked. Sponsors are paid. Pepsi already shot the commercial.

TYRESE
It's an audition, Russ. It's one Monday.

RUSSELL
It's an audition for a movie that shoots June through November in England. Exactly when you'll be in Brazil, Japan, Germany, and Ohio, singing "Baby Don't Stop" to eighty thousand screaming girls a night.

Tyrese stands and walks to the window. Below, the Donohue lot hums in the sun, with the Mickey Mouse water tower in the distance.

TYRESE
You know what they said about me after STARLIGHT AVENUE? "Stick to singing." The Razzie people sent me a statue. My mom keeps it in the bathroom so she can laugh at it.

RUSSELL
That was six years ago.

TYRESE
It's still every review. Every script I get is a pop star playing a pop star. Nobody's ever let me play a man.

(turning back to him)
Steve Rogers isn't a man who sings to eighty thousand people, Russ. He's a skinny kid from Brooklyn who gets beat up in alleys and won't stay down. He gets picked because he's GOOD. Not because he's famous. Do you understand how badly I need someone to pick me because I'm good?

Russell looks at his biggest star. For a moment, the businessman almost softens. Then he doesn't.

RUSSELL
Go to your audition, Tyrese. And when they offer it to you, I'll say no for you. That's my job.

CUT TO:

INT. RALEIGH STUDIOS - REHEARSAL HALL B - HOLLYWOOD - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, MARCH 1, 2010 - 10:00 A.M. PST

The rehearsal hall where Amond became the Hulk. At the long table: JOE JOHNSTON (59), director of THE ROCKETEER, in a flannel shirt; KEVIN FEIGE (36); casting director SARAH FINN; and LENORA HAYES (44). On the wall, a 1941 poster: CAPTAIN AMERICA COMICS #1, Cap punching Hitler.

First up: JULIAN SMILLEY (33), handsome, polished, in a perfect gray suit. He finishes the scene: Steve Rogers at the enlistment office, rejected for the fifth time.

JULIAN (AS STEVE)
I've been told no in five cities, Doctor. I'll keep coming back until somebody says yes. I don't want to kill anyone. I just don't like bullies.

Silence. It was good. Smooth, warm, very good.

JOHNSTON
Thank you, Julian. That was lovely.

JULIAN
(smiling, gracious)
Thank you for having me. I know my family name doesn't exactly open doors at this studio. I appreciate you seeing me anyway.

FEIGE
Your family name has nothing to do with this room. I promise.

Julian nods and leaves. Johnston turns to the others.

JOHNSTON
He's very good.

SARAH FINN
He's very good at being liked. Steve Rogers isn't trying to be liked.

The door opens. TYRESE AVERY walks in. No entourage. Jeans, a plain white T-shirt. No jewelry. He looks smaller than he does on stage, somehow younger.

He stops in front of the table and looks at the poster of Cap punching Hitler.

TYRESE
My grandfather fought in the Battle of the Bulge. 1944. He came home and they wouldn't let him eat at the lunch counter in his own town in Georgia. He still had the uniform on.

(beat)
He used to read me CAPTAIN AMERICA comics when I was little. I asked him once why he liked Cap so much, when America treated him like that.

JOHNSTON
(quietly)
What did he say?

TYRESE
He said, "Because Cap is what America is supposed to be, baby. Somebody's got to remember what it's supposed to be."

The room is very quiet. Johnston nods slowly.

JOHNSTON
Whenever you're ready.

Tyrese closes his eyes. When he opens them, the pop star has disappeared. In his place is a skinny, stubborn kid from Brooklyn who has been told no too many times.

TYRESE (AS STEVE)
I know what you see, Doctor. Ninety pounds. Asthma. Flat feet. A heart that skips. I know what everybody sees.

(beat, steady)
But I've been knocked down in every alley in Brooklyn, and I've gotten up every single time. Not because I'm strong. Because somebody's got to stand up, and nobody else in that alley ever does.

(a long pause, his voice dropping)
You want to know why I keep coming back? It's not to kill anybody. There are people over there being dragged out of their homes in the middle of the night. Somebody has to go get them.

(looking directly at Johnston)
Let it be me.

Silence. Sarah Finn has stopped writing. Lenora has a hand at her throat.

JOHNSTON
(after a long moment)
...Can you do the jump?

The famous comic moment: a fake grenade thrown into a crowd of recruits. Everyone scatters. Only the skinny kid throws himself on top of it. Johnston nods to a STUNT COORDINATOR, who tosses a dummy grenade onto the floor without warning.

Before anyone can blink, Tyrese DIVES on top of it, curling his body around it, his arms wrapped over his head. He yells at the empty room.

TYRESE (AS STEVE)
GET BACK! EVERYBODY GET BACK!

A beat. Nothing happens. Tyrese stays curled on the floor, eyes shut, waiting to die. Then he slowly lifts his head and looks around, confused, breathing hard.

TYRESE (AS STEVE) (CONT'D)
(small, embarrassed)
...Is this a test?

Johnston laughs out loud, a big surprised laugh, and claps his hands once.

JOHNSTON
That's him. That's Steve Rogers. He didn't think. He just jumped.

FEIGE
(quietly, to Lenora)
Can we get him?

LENORA
(already flipping through a file)
His label has him on a ninety-four-city world tour from June to November. Hollywood Records. Which, as of December 31, is owned by Donohue.

FEIGE
And page forty says Donohue can't touch casting.

LENORA
Page forty says Donohue can't touch casting. It doesn't say anything about Donohue's record label letting its biggest star skip a two-hundred-million-dollar tour.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - DESMOND'S STUDY - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, MARCH 2, 2010 - 9:00 P.M. PST

DESMOND (52) sits behind his desk. JULIAN (33) stands in front of it, still in the suit from his audition, his tie loosened.

DESMOND
The casting director told your agent it was down to two. You and the pop singer. The pop singer has a world tour he can't get out of. Do you understand what that means?

JULIAN
It means if he can't get out of it, I get it.

DESMOND
It means a phone call. One phone call to the right person at Hollywood Records, and that tour becomes impossible to break. I still know people there from 1988...

JULIAN
No.

Desmond stops.

DESMOND
Excuse me?

JULIAN
No, Dad. No phone calls. No Gerald Whitfields. No leaks. No StarDish.

(beat, steady)
I watched his tape. Sarah Finn's assistant showed it to my agent. He jumped on a grenade, Dad. He didn't even think about it. I would have thought about it. That's the difference between us. That's why he's Captain America and I'm not.

DESMOND
(rising)
Julian, you are a Smilley...

JULIAN
I know what I am. I'm a thirty-three-year-old man who's been doing what you wanted since I was nine. I lost Iron Man. I'll lose this. And I'm going to lose it clean.

(heading for the door, then stopping)
You know what Esther said to me the day she got Thor? She said, "Maybe somebody in this family should let it stop." I'm letting it stop.

He walks out. Desmond stands alone in his study, stunned. Two of his children now. One by one, they're walking out of the war.

CUT TO:

INT. TYRESE AVERY'S MANSION - MUSIC ROOM - CALABASAS - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, MARCH 11, 2010 - 10:30 P.M. PST

A gleaming home studio. Gold records on every wall. Tyrese sits at a grand piano, not playing. On the piano: a contract from Marvel Studios, and a much thicker document, "AVERY WORLD TOUR 2010 - TERMINATION PENALTIES."

His manager, CORINNE AVERY (52), his mother, sits on the couch with reading glasses and a calculator.

CORINNE
Eighteen million dollars, baby. If you cancel the tour yourself, you pay the promoters, the sponsors, the stadiums, the crew. Eighteen million. Out of your own pocket.

TYRESE
And if I do the tour?

CORINNE
Then Marvel goes with the Smilley boy, and you go back to singing "Baby Don't Stop" for another twenty years.

Tyrese plays one note on the piano. Then another.

TYRESE
Mama. What would Granddaddy say?

Corinne takes off her reading glasses. She looks at her son for a long time.

CORINNE
Your grandfather walked across Europe in the snow so a country that didn't want him could stay free. He'd say eighteen million dollars is a small price to be what America's supposed to be.

(beat, a small smile)
And then he'd say "ouch."

Tyrese laughs. Then he picks up a pen and signs the Marvel contract. Then he picks up his phone and dials.

TYRESE
Russ. It's me. I'm canceling the tour.

(listening, a torrent of yelling on the other end)
I know. I know. I'll pay it. All of it. Every penny. Out of my own account. You don't have to do anything. Just let me go.

(listening)
Then sue me, Russ. Sue Captain America. See how that looks.

He hangs up. His mother is crying. He walks over and hugs her.

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT - NATASHA BULLOCK'S OFFICE - BURBANK - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, MARCH 12, 2010 - 9:00 A.M. PST

NATASHA (48) sits at her desk. RUSSELL KANE stands in front of her, red-faced, holding a legal folder.

RUSSELL
He canceled ninety-four dates. Pepsi is furious. The promoters are furious. I want to sue him for breach. We have every right.

NATASHA
Has he offered to pay the penalties?

RUSSELL
In full. Personally. Eighteen million.

NATASHA
Then he hasn't breached anything, Russell. He's paid for his freedom.

RUSSELL
Natasha, with respect, he's our biggest artist. If we let him walk away from a world tour to make a movie for Marvel...

NATASHA
Which we also own.

RUSSELL
Which we also own, yes, but which I'm told we're not allowed to discuss.

Natasha sets down her pen.

NATASHA
Russell. I'm not going to make a single decision about who plays Captain America. That's Kevin's job, and I gave him my word. But I can make a decision about Hollywood Records. And my decision is this: Donohue Entertainment does not sue Captain America.

(beat)
Accept the money. Reschedule the tour for 2012. Put out a statement saying we're proud of him. And Russell?

RUSSELL
(deflated)
Yes?

NATASHA
The next time an artist on my label tells you he needs someone to pick him because he's good, listen.

CUT TO:

MARVEL STUDIOS - PRESS RELEASE - MONDAY, MARCH 22, 2010, 6:00 AM PT

TYRESE AVERY IS CAPTAIN AMERICA

Joe Johnston Directs "Captain America: The First Avenger," Shooting This Summer on Location in England and New York for July 22, 2011 Release

LOS ANGELES - Marvel Studios today announced that Tyrese Avery will star as Steve Rogers in CAPTAIN AMERICA: THE FIRST AVENGER, directed by Joe Johnston from a screenplay by Christopher Markus & Stephen McFeely.

Faithful to the 1941 comics by Joe Simon and Jack Kirby, the film follows Steve Rogers, a frail young man from Brooklyn who volunteers for a top-secret Super-Soldier experiment during World War II. Avery will perform Steve's transformation and all of Captain America's combat himself, with visual effects used only to portray his pre-serum physique.

"Tyrese's audition had the purest moment of courage any of us has ever seen in a room," said Joe Johnston. "We threw a fake grenade on the floor without warning, and he was on top of it before we could blink. That's Steve Rogers."

"Tyrese gave up a world tour to play this role," said Kevin Feige. "That's the most Captain America thing anyone could do."

MONTAGE - THE WORLD REACTS TO CAPTAIN AVERY

SUPER: MONDAY, MARCH 22, 2010

BILLBOARD - BREAKING NEWS - MARCH 22, 2010

TYRESE AVERY CANCELS 2010 WORLD TOUR, PAYS $18M IN PENALTIES TO PLAY CAPTAIN AMERICA

Hollywood Records confirms the "Avery World Tour" will be rescheduled for 2012. "We're proud of him," says label president Russell Kane, in a statement sources say he did not write.

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "OFFICIAL: TYRESE AVERY IS CAPTAIN AMERICA" (Page 1 of 522)

ShellHead1963 (Mar 22, 6:10 AM)
A POP STAR as Captain America. Here we go again. I'm 44 years old and I've learned my lesson four times. I'm just going to post apology #210 in advance and save everybody the time.

WarMachineRox (Mar 22, 6:22 AM)
He paid EIGHTEEN MILLION DOLLARS out of his own pocket to cancel a world tour so he could play Steve Rogers. That's not a pop star. That's Steve Rogers.

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Mar 22, 6:30 AM)
The grenade story from the press release. "He was on top of it before we could blink." CHILLS.

NoNerfsPlz (Mar 22, 6:41 AM)
Tyrese's grandfather fought in the Battle of the Bulge and couldn't eat at a lunch counter when he came home. It's in the Variety interview. Cap has always been about what America is SUPPOSED to be. This casting is perfect.

Mjolnir_Worthy (Mar 22, 7:02 AM)
Iron Man, Hulk, Ant-Man, Wasp, Thor, Black Widow, now Cap. The Avengers is almost fully cast. Who's Hawkeye???

Repulsor_Ray (Mar 22, 7:15 AM)
i know it's tyrese AVERY. but my mom thought it was tyrese GIBSON. she asked if optimus prime is going to be in it

TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - MONDAY, MARCH 22, 2010

#CaptainAvery - Tyrese Avery - $18 Million - #AveryArmy - Not Tyrese Gibson

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

tyreseavery: to the #AveryArmy: i'm sorry about the tour. i'll make it up to you in 2012. to everybody else: i've been waiting my whole life for someone to pick me because i was good. thank you @marvel. this one's for granddaddy. 6:05 AM Mar 22nd from web

marcanthonyb: welcome to the team, captain. the shield suits you. call me if you need anything. also i will be calling you "cap" forever now 6:30 AM Mar 22nd from web

amondbaker: the man jumped on a grenade in an audition. i jumped on a bagel table once. we are not the same 7:12 AM Mar 22nd from web

AveryArmy_Official: we lost a world tour but we gained captain america. #AveryArmy will be at every midnight screening in july 2011. 9:00 AM Mar 22nd from web

BET - "106 & PARK" - LIVE - MONDAY, MARCH 22, 2010 - ON-SCREEN SCROLL

BREAKING: TYRESE AVERY IS CAPTAIN AMERICA! That's Iron Man, the Hulk, the Wasp, Thor, Black Widow and Captain America, all played by Black actors. This is history.

TWITTER.COM - DIRECT MESSAGE (shared later by Tyrese in a 2015 interview)

From: juliansmilley To: tyreseavery - Mar 22, 2010, 10:14 AM

Congratulations, man. I watched your tape. You earned it. You jumped. I would have thought about it. Go make them proud. - J

CUT TO:

VARIETY - MONDAY, APRIL 12, 2010

CHAPMAN TO PLAY BUCKY IN 'CAPTAIN AMERICA'

Actor-musician Tyler Chapman, last seen in a canceled cable drama, will play Steve Rogers' best friend James "Bucky" Barnes. Hayley Atwell is Peggy Carter. Michael Ealy is Howard Stark.

CUT TO:

EXT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - HOLLYWOOD BOULEVARD - EVENING

SUPER: MONDAY, APRIL 26, 2010 - 6:00 P.M. PDT - THE IRON MAN 2 PREMIERE

The historic movie palace, owned by Donohue Entertainment, its neon marquee blazing: "IRON MAN 2 - WORLD PREMIERE." A red carpet the length of a football field. A giant practical MARK VI armor and the silver WAR MACHINE armor stand in the forecourt.

MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (28) steps out of a car in a charcoal three-piece suit. The screams are deafening.

E! CORRESPONDENT
Marc-Anthony! First premiere since your mom bought Marvel. Does it feel different?

MARC-ANTHONY
Only one thing's different. The bagels at craft services are now owned by my mother. Otherwise, it's still Kevin's house.

Down the carpet: DON CHEADLE (45) in a military-cut tux, HARMONY DIVINE (27) in a black catsuit-inspired gown with AMOND BAKER (28), her "friend," as both keep insisting, on her arm, TAYIA BOYD (28) in Pepper-blue, MICKEY ROURKE (57) with a dog, SAM ROCKWELL (41) doing a little dance, SAMUEL L. JACKSON (61) in an eyepatch for fun, CLARK GREGG (48) as Coulson in a black suit, and STAN LEE (87).

Then the crowd turns. A black SUV pulls up. Out steps TOM HIDDLESTON (29) in a green velvet jacket. He turns and offers his hand to the woman behind him.

ESTHER SMILLEY (27). A sleek midnight-blue gown with silver accents and a cape. Her hair in a warrior braid. On her shoulder, Cornelius's gold crown pin.

The crowd SCREAMS. "THOR! THOR! THOR!" The paparazzi lose their minds.

ACCESS HOLLYWOOD CORRESPONDENT
Esther! We thought you were shooting in Iceland!

ESTHER
We wrapped New Mexico on Friday. Kevin said the Avengers family shows up for each other. So here I am.

ACCESS HOLLYWOOD CORRESPONDENT
And your father? Does he know you're here?

A tiny pause. Then Esther smiles her famous smile.

ESTHER
He has a television.

Further down the carpet, Marc-Anthony is mid-interview when he hears the screams. He turns. Sees her. For one unguarded second, his face does something every camera on Hollywood Boulevard catches.

Then Esther reaches him. They stand face to face on the red carpet. A hundred flashbulbs explode.

MARC-ANTHONY
(polite, public)
Esther. Congratulations on wrapping New Mexico.

ESTHER
(polite, public)
Thank you. Congratulations on Iron Man 2. I hear you're very drunk in it.

MARC-ANTHONY
Method acting. I had to research.

A PHOTOGRAPHER yells: "Iron Man and Thor! Together! Look over here!" They turn and pose side by side. Not touching. Exactly six inches apart. The most famous six inches in Hollywood.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
(through his smile, not moving his lips)
You came.

ESTHER
(through her smile)
Kevin said the family shows up.

MARC-ANTHONY
(through his smile)
Kevin's very wise.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - FAMILY ROOM - VIEW PARK - SAME TIME

E! is live on the big TV. On screen: Marc-Anthony and Esther, side by side, six inches apart, smiling for the cameras.

DESMOND (52) stands in front of the TV, his arms crossed. CELESTE (50) sits on the couch. SIMONE (30) eats popcorn. CORNELIUS (76) sits in his armchair. JULIAN (33) leans in the doorway.

E! HOST (V.O.)
...and look at that, Iron Man and Thor! Marc-Anthony Bullock and Esther Smilley! The Donohue heir and the Smilley heiress, together on the carpet! Hollywood's Romeo and Juliet, anyone?

SIMONE
(cheerfully, mouth full)
She looks amazing.

DESMOND
(quietly)
She told us she was in New Mexico until Wednesday.

SIMONE
They wrapped early. It happens. Film is unpredictable.

On screen, the camera catches Marc-Anthony's face as he first sees Esther arrive. That unguarded second. The E! producers replay it in slow motion.

E! HOST (V.O.)
...oh, now THAT's a look! Did you see that look? We're going to play that again...

Desmond grabs the remote and turns off the TV. The room goes silent.

CORNELIUS
(softly, from his chair)
I've seen that look before, Desmond.

DESMOND
(not turning around)
Where?

CORNELIUS
On a rooftop in Harlem, in 1958. On my own face.
In a photograph.

Desmond turns around slowly to stare at his father. Cornelius doesn't explain. He just looks at the dark TV screen.

CUT TO:

INT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - AUDITORIUM - NIGHT

SUPER: MONDAY, APRIL 26, 2010 - 9:45 P.M. PDT

The movie has just ended. The audience is on its feet: Tony Stark, Rhodey and the Black Widow have defeated Whiplash's drone army at the Stark Expo in a stunning, practical finale. Harmony's one-take hallway fight got a standing ovation in the middle of the movie.

The credits roll. Nobody leaves. Nobody EVER leaves anymore.

On screen: a desert at night. NEW MEXICO. Wind. A black sedan pulls up to a huge crater surrounded by S.H.I.E.L.D. floodlights. AGENT COULSON (Clark Gregg) steps out and walks to the edge of the crater. He looks down. He lifts a phone to his ear.

CLARK GREGG (ON SCREEN, AS COULSON)
Sir. We found it.

The camera pushes down into the crater. At the bottom, embedded in the rock, glowing faintly in the floodlights: a hammer. Runes on its sides. A leather-wrapped handle.

On its face, just barely readable in the light: "...IF SHE BE WORTHY..."

Black. "THOR - MAY 6, 2011."

The El Capitan EXPLODES. In the middle of the auditorium, Esther grips the armrests of her seat. Hiddleston, beside her, leans over.

HIDDLESTON
(whispering)
That's your hammer, sister.

ESTHER
(whispering, overwhelmed)
That's my hammer.

Three rows ahead, Marc-Anthony turns around in his seat. He finds her in the dark. He mouths, silently: "YOUR HAMMER." She covers her mouth to keep from laughing out loud.

In the aisle, Natasha (48), standing with Feige, sees the whole thing. She looks at her son. Then at the Smilley girl. Then back at her son. She doesn't say a word.

CUT TO:

EXT. HOLLYWOOD AND HIGHLAND - ROOFTOP TERRACE - AFTERPARTY - NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, APRIL 27, 2010 - 12:40 A.M. PDT

The afterparty is packed below. On a quiet, dark corner of the rooftop, far from the crowd, Marc-Anthony and Esther stand at the railing looking at the lights of Hollywood. Not touching. Talking quietly. For once, there's no one around.

ESTHER
My father knows I'm here.

MARC-ANTHONY
Your father has a television.

ESTHER
(a small laugh)
You saw that?

MARC-ANTHONY
Everybody saw that. E! has played it eleven times.

(beat)
They also played my face eleven times. When you walked in.

ESTHER
I saw.

MARC-ANTHONY
I didn't plan it.

ESTHER
I know. That's what made it so good.

They look at each other. Below them, the party roars on.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
I have three more weeks in Iceland. Then reshoots in London. Then press. Then...

MARC-ANTHONY
Then the Avengers. Next year. London. We'll be on the same set for six months.

ESTHER
Six months.

MARC-ANTHONY
That's a long time to pretend we met at a Kids' Choice Awards.

Esther looks at him. Her hand moves on the railing, just an inch, until it's almost touching his. Not quite.

ESTHER
(very softly)
Ask me again in London.

Neither of them notices: on a balcony of the hotel across Highland Avenue, a single PAPARAZZO (40s) with a telephoto lens the size of a fire extinguisher. Click. Click. Click.

CUT TO:

MONTAGE - IRON MAN 2 OPENS

SUPER: FRIDAY, MAY 7 - SUNDAY, MAY 9, 2010

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "OFFICIAL IRON MAN 2 DISCUSSION - SPOILERS" (Page 1 of 377)

ShellHead1963 (May 7, 12:30 AM)
Tony's drunk birthday party in the Mark IV. That's DEMON IN A BOTTLE. They're setting up the alcoholism arc. Comic accurate to the bone. Marc-Anthony plays it heartbreaking.

WarMachineRox (May 7, 12:41 AM)
WAR MACHINE. DON CHEADLE. The Expo fight with Rhodey and Tony back to back. My life is complete. Terrence, we'll always love you.

NoNerfsPlz (May 7, 12:55 AM)
HARMONY DIVINE'S HALLWAY FIGHT. ONE TAKE. NO CUTS. ALL HER. Marvel Method is unreal.

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (May 7, 1:10 AM)
THE HAMMER. IN THE CRATER. "IF SHE BE WORTHY." Thor is NEXT. I'm screaming.

Repulsor_Ray (May 7, 1:30 AM)
Did anyone else see the TMZ pics from the afterparty?? Marc-Anthony and Esther Smilley on the roof at 1 a.m.?? Alone??

TMZ.COM - FRIDAY, MAY 7, 2010

IRON MAN & THOR: ROOFTOP RENDEZVOUS?!

Marc-Anthony Bullock and Esther Smilley were spotted alone on a dark rooftop at the "Iron Man 2" afterparty at 12:40 a.m., talking for nearly an hour. Sources say their hands were "inches apart." Her father, Desmond Smilley, could not be reached for comment. Insiders say he's been "very reachable" by private investigators.

DEADLINE HOLLYWOOD - SUNDAY, MAY 9, 2010, 9:30 AM PT

IRON MAN 2 STRIKES GOLD: $134.7M OPENING! MARVEL 5-FOR-5

Marvel's fifth film and first under Donohue ownership has crushed expectations: $51.2M Friday, $43.6M Saturday, an estimated $39.9M Sunday. A+ CinemaScore. 79% on Rotten Tomatoes. Bigger than the original by $30M. And the post-credits tease of Thor's hammer is driving repeat viewings. Oh, and TMZ's rooftop photos? I'm told they're the most-searched celebrity images of the weekend.

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ESTATE - SUNROOM - BEL AIR - DAY

SUPER: SUNDAY, MAY 9, 2010 - 11:00 A.M. PDT - MOTHER'S DAY

Mother's Day brunch. Flowers everywhere. NATASHA (48) sits with a mimosa. Marc-Anthony comes in carrying an enormous bouquet of white roses and a printed sheet of paper.

MARC-ANTHONY
Happy Mother's Day. One hundred and thirty-four point seven million dollars.

He hands her the box office report with the roses. She laughs, takes both, and pulls him into a hug.

NATASHA
That's the second-best Mother's Day present I've ever gotten.

MARC-ANTHONY
What was the first?

NATASHA
You. Born at Cedars-Sinai during the worst rainstorm of January 1982. Your father fainted.

Marc-Anthony laughs and sits beside her. A comfortable silence. Then Natasha picks up the Sunday L.A. TIMES from the table and unfolds it to the Calendar section. A full-page photo from TMZ: Marc-Anthony and Esther on the dark rooftop, inches apart.

Natasha sets the paper down between them. She doesn't say anything. She just looks at him.

MARC-ANTHONY
(carefully)
Mom...

NATASHA
How long?

Marc-Anthony looks at his mother. At the photo. Back at his mother. He could lie. He has never lied to her.

MARC-ANTHONY
Since we were eleven, we've been friends. Since I was twenty-four, it's been... more than that. For me. I don't know what it is for her. We've never... nothing's ever happened, Mom. Nothing.

NATASHA
"Not against anyone. Including people this family doesn't like."

MARC-ANTHONY
Yeah.

NATASHA
(a long breath)
Desmond Smilley's daughter.

MARC-ANTHONY
Esther.

Natasha looks out the window at the garden for a long time. When she speaks, her voice is very quiet.

NATASHA
Your grandfather once had a best friend he loved more than anyone in the world. They haven't spoken in forty-three years. I've watched him look at the phone on election night like it might bite him.

(turning back to her son)
I'm not going to let that happen to you, Marc.

MARC-ANTHONY
(stunned)
...You're not mad?

NATASHA
Oh, I'm furious. Her father wrote a column calling my company a monopoly. Her family has hated mine since before I was born.

(beat, a small smile)
But I've also watched her lift a hammer that weighs fifteen pounds over her head in front of six thousand people. That girl is not afraid of anything. You could do much worse.

Marc-Anthony puts his head on his mother's shoulder like he did when he was a kid.

NATASHA (CONT'D)
(stroking his hair)
Just do me one favor.

MARC-ANTHONY
Anything.

NATASHA
Don't let me read about it in TMZ again.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - FRONT HALL - VIEW PARK - DAY

SUPER: SUNDAY, MAY 9, 2010 - 2:00 P.M. PDT - MOTHER'S DAY

Esther comes through the front door carrying a bouquet of yellow tulips, her mother's favorite. On the hall table, the morning mail: Celeste has left a padded envelope for her, addressed in neat block capitals: "MISS ESTHER SMILLEY - PERSONAL."

No return address. Esther opens it. Inside: a single SD memory card, and a folded note on plain paper.

HANDWRITTEN NOTE (in the envelope)

Miss Smilley,

Two years ago your father hired me to follow you. On June 10, 2008, I took photographs of you and Mr. Bullock at Children's Hospital, making paper crowns with sick kids. I told your father I saw nothing. I've kept this card in my glove compartment ever since.

I'm retiring. I'm giving it to the only person it belongs to.

Your father saw the rooftop pictures this morning. He called me again. I told him I'm out.

He knows now, Miss Smilley. Be careful. And for what it's worth, you two looked happy. I've been doing this for thirty years. That's rarer than you'd think.

- R.K.

Esther reads it twice. Her hands are shaking. She looks up the stairs toward her father's closed study door.

Behind it, faintly, she can hear his voice on the phone. Cold. Measured. The voice she's heard her whole life when he's planning something.

She slips the memory card into her pocket. She walks into the kitchen, where Celeste is arranging flowers, and hands her mother the tulips with a perfect smile.

ESTHER
Happy Mother's Day, Mama.

CELESTE
(touched, taking them)
Oh, tulips. You remembered.

Celeste looks at her daughter's face. Something in it makes her pause.

CELESTE (CONT'D)
Baby. Are you all right?

A long beat. For the first time in her life, Esther doesn't give her mother the perfect smile.

ESTHER
(quietly)
Mama, I need to tell you something. Not today. But soon.

Celeste looks at her youngest child. She doesn't ask. She puts down the tulips and pulls Esther into a hug, and holds on for a long time.

FADE OUT.

MONDAY HEADLINES

SUPER: MONDAY, MAY 10, 2010

VARIETY - MON MAY 10, 2010

'IRON MAN 2' SOARS TO $134.7M; MARVEL 5-FOR-5

Bullock, Cheadle and Divine power the biggest opening of 2010 so far; post-credits hammer reveal primes "Thor" for next May.

ENTERTAINMENT WEEKLY - COVER (Issue of May 21, 2010)

CAPTAIN AMERICA IS CALLING: Tyrese Avery Gave Up $18 Million for the Shield

"I want to be picked because I'm good." Inside the pop star's leap of faith.

US WEEKLY - COVER (Issue of May 24, 2010)

IRON MAN & THOR: FORBIDDEN LOVE?

Rooftop photos! Secret glances! Feuding families! Inside Hollywood's Romeo and Juliet.

JET MAGAZINE - "PEOPLE ARE TALKING ABOUT" (Issue of May 24, 2010)

Six Black Superheroes and Counting

Iron Man, the Hulk, the Wasp, Thor, Black Widow and Captain America. Marvel's universe now has more Black leads than any franchise in Hollywood history. Also: is View Park about to go to war again?

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER ELEVEN